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Local grammar approaches to speech acts in Chinese: A case study of exemplification

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ABSTRACT

This study develops a local grammar of exemplification in Chinese and also briefly discusses local grammar analyses of apologies in five selected languages, aiming to explore the feasibility of employing the local grammar approach to account for speech acts in various languages. Using data taken from DiSCUSS, a balanced and representative corpus of spoken Chinese, the analyses identified 13 local grammar patterns of exemplification, which shows the applicability of local grammars in describing speech act realisations in languages other than English. Our discussion further suggests that the resulting local grammar descriptions can not only reveal language-specific features of speech act realisations, but also facilitates contrastive (e.g., cross-linguistic and cross-cultural) speech act studies. The theoretical implications for describing speech act realisations and pedagogical applications for teaching speech acts in L2 contexts are also discussed. It is concluded that local grammar can be a useful and viable approach that can significantly take forward speech act studies.

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1. Introduction

This study aims to explore the feasibility of employing the local grammar approach to account for speech act realisations in languages other than English. To that end, the study develops a local grammar of exemplification in Chinese and further presents a brief discussion of the local grammar analyses of apologies in five selected languages (i.e., Chinese, Japanese, English, French, and German). Simply put, local grammar is an approach to language description that seeks to account for specific discourse or communicative functions such as evaluation and apology (e.g., Hunston and Sinclair, 2000; Su and Wei, 2018; Section 2). The concept of speech act is usually interpreted as doing by saying (Austin, 1962), which, however, is much more complex than it appears to be. It involves a number of theoretical issues (e.g., taxonomy of speech acts, speech act interpretation) which have not been adequately addressed and go far beyond the scope of the current investigation (see Levinson, 2017 for more discussion). For the sake of simplicity, the notion of speech act here is used in its broadest sense, i.e., as an umbrella term covering most kinds of discourse or communicative functions that local grammars attempt to account for. The proposed synergy indicates the compatibility between local grammars and speech act studies (see also Su, 2017; Su and Wei, 2018).

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The usability of developing local grammars of speech acts can draw further support from Butler's (2004: 158) argument that "rather than a single general grammar, we might end up with a set of local grammars for particular areas defined by their communicative functions in the discourse". Barnbrook and Sinclair (2001: 273), based on their research on the local grammar of definition, have argued even more strongly that the kind of specialised description offered by local grammar can "outperform" that offered by general grammars. Multiple studies have thus employed the local grammar approach to account for various speech acts such as request (Su, 2017), disclaiming (Cheng and Ching, 2018), apology (Su and Wei, 2018), and definition (Zhang and Su, 2022). These studies have not only demonstrated the usefulness of local grammars in speech act studies, but have also shown that the resulting local grammar descriptions could have important pedagogical applications for teaching targeted speech acts in second language (L2) contexts (see more discussion in Section 4).

It should be noted, however, that previous studies have only applied the local grammar approach to account for speech acts in English. Notwithstanding the value of previous research, it raises the question as to whether local grammars can also be used to describe speech acts in languages other than English. In this study we address this question by applying the local grammar approach to account for speech acts in Chinese, focusing specifically on 例举 (meaning 'exemplification' in English; Section 2.2) – the act of providing examples for illustration and/or specification. Our overarching goal is to explore whether the local grammar approach can be applied to account for speech acts in various languages and to further discuss the implications and applications of this kind of research.

2. Local grammars and speech act studies in Chinese

2.1. Local grammar

The concept of local grammar has been comprehensively discussed in studies such as Hunston and Sinclair (2000), Su (2017) and Su and Wei (2018). Simply put, local grammar is considered an alternative approach, as opposed to general grammars, to language description. It differs from general grammars in that each local grammar "seeks to account for, not the whole of a language, but one meaning only" (Hunston, 2002: 178). Meaning here is to be interpreted as an equivalent to discourse or communicative function and as such Hunston and Su (2019: 571) note that each local grammar "is always a grammar of a discourse function".

Another defining feature that distinguishes local grammar from general grammar lies in the terminologies used for analysing language use. As is widely known, general grammar uses grammatical terminologies such as Subject, Predicate and Object to analyse language used in all kinds of contexts. In contrast, local grammar employs functional terminologies to describe language use associated with a specific discourse function; and the advantage of doing so is that the resulting description is more transparent and can thereby more easily reveal the pragmatic function of language use. This has been well illustrated in Su and Wei (2018) with the simple example *I apologise*, as shown in Table 1.

Table 1(a)
General grammar analysis (Su and Wei, 2018: 456).

Subject	Predicate
I	Apologise

Table 1(b)
The alternative local grammar analysis (Su and Wei, 2018: 456).

Apologiser	Apologising
I	Apologise

Su and Wei (2018) pointed out that, as Table 1(a) can only be a simplistic rendering of general grammatical analysis, it suggests that the description offered by general grammars cannot reveal the pragmatic or communicative function of the utterance *I apologise*. That is, the Subject-Predicate sequence tells us nothing about the function of the utterance as an apology. In contrast, the local grammar analysis using context-specific terms such as Apologiser and Apologising clearly indicates that the pragmatic or communicative function of the utterance is apology-making. Su and Wei (2018: 456) thus argued that "local grammars are particularly useful for accounting for pragmatic functions", which has also been amply demonstrated in many other studies (e.g., Cheng and Ching, 2018; Su and Zhang, 2020; Zhang and Su, 2022).

At this point, a discussion of two methodological issues concerning local grammar research is in order. The first relates to the retrieval of instances realising the target speech act. Barnbrook and Sinclair (2001: 243) similarly noted that "local grammars carry an extra burden over general grammars in that they have to identify in the flow of open text the textual units that are relevant to them". Early studies have either used manual identification (e.g., Cheng and Ching, 2018) or semi-automatic computerised search of lexical or syntactic markers to address this issue (e.g., Su, 2017; Su and Wei, 2018). Overall, in the case of speech act studies, data retrieval largely depends upon the degree of how conventional or routinised the

realisations of a given speech act are. The more conventional or routinised, the more likely instances of the target speech act can be (semi-)automatically retrieved.

The other issue is concerned with the selection of a set of appropriate local grammar terminologies (LGT) for the subsequent analysis. This might be challenging, because selecting such terminologies requires the analyst to decode the semantic and/or pragmatic relationship between the syntactic units of a speech act instance. Nonetheless, this has been shown to be relatively easy in speech act studies, as "the selection of local grammar terminology is justified by the speech act being employed" (Hunston and Su, 2019: 572).

2.2. A local grammar approach to speech acts in Chinese

The theory of speech act generally advocates that in saying something we are also doing something beyond our phonetic act, i.e., we perform a social action (Austin, 1962). Speech acts are not only the basic unit of language analysis or in Searle's (1969: 16) words, "the basic or minimal units of linguistic communication", but are also ubiquitous in all languages, as one of the major functions of language is for communication (Vanderveken, 2001; DeCapua and Dunham, 2007). This points to the necessity and importance to investigate speech acts in and across languages/contexts, which in turn requires exploring viable methods that can further such studies.

As noted at the beginning of this paper, local grammars have been shown to be a useful methodological candidate for advancing speech act studies in English (e.g., Su, 2017; Su and Wei, 2018). However, the question as to whether local grammars can also be employed to account for speech acts in languages other than English has not been addressed. Therefore, this study attempts to bridge this gap by extending the local grammar approach to describe speech acts in Chinese, with the current investigation zooming in on the speech act of exemplification.

While exemplification may appear to be somewhat different from the other more 'prototypical' speech acts such as apology and request, we consider it a speech act because instances of exemplification can also be paraphrased by using the formula "In saying U, S performs an Act of V-ing" (Gu, 2015: 3). In other words, in uttering an expression of exemplification the speaker performs the act of exemplifying. For instance, just as it can be said that the speaker performs the speech act of apologising when s/he says *I'm sorry for the interruption*, it can be similarly said that the speaker performs the speech act of exemplifying when s/he says *An example of an artist acting directly as a critic is Bridget Riley* (A04 129; British National Corpus).

Arguably, exemplification may be categorised as representatives in terms of Searle's (1976) taxonomy of speech acts (i.e., asserting, supplying more information); more specifically, the speaker/writer asserts that something is a subtype of, or illustrates, another thing and, accordingly, its main illocutionary force is to give examples or provide subtypes to illustrate abstract concepts or to specify superordinate categories (Su and Zhang, 2020). Exemplification is selected as the focus of the study because it plays a significant role in communication, as appropriate performance of this act contributes to the interaction and accessibility of a conversation/text (Hyland, 2007). Despite its significance in social interaction, exemplification has not attracted as much attention as other speech acts in Chinese such as refusal (Ren and Woodfield, 2016), invitation (Yu and Wu, 2018) and self-praise (Wu, 2011; Ren and Guo, 2020). An examination of the few studies that investigated exemplification in Chinese suggests that previous studies usually take exemplificatory markers in Chinese as discourse markers, as they primarily function as connectives, connecting two different parts of complex clauses or sentences (e.g., Li, 2011; Wang, 2016). However, no attempt has yet been made to document and describe the lexicogrammatical realisations of exemplification in Chinese, which, in fact, also applies to the other Chinese speech acts that have been examined, as discussed below.

For instance, Chen et al. (1995) used Discourse Completion Tasks (DCTs) to collect refusals by native speakers of Mandarin Chinese and, based on their data analyses, they found several pragmatic strategies for making refusals such as reasoning, direct refusal, and expressing regret. Ren and Woodfield (2016) investigated date refusals made by Chinese females in TV shows and observed that they used a limited range of pragmatic strategies (e.g., making apologies, offering reasons, expressing gratitude). Yu and Wu (2018) examined invitation in Mandarin Chinese within the framework of conversation analysis. Their detailed analyses of recorded daily conversations lead to the identification of three syntactic forms (interrogatives, imperatives, and declaratives) that are typically associated with invitation. With regard to self-praise, Wu (2011), drawing on data taken from recorded face-to-face conversations, identified three patterns for performing self-praise (i.e., bipartite turn-constructional format, disclaiming an extreme case situation, and treating the matter as complainable) and subsequently discussed the interactional contingencies that may lead to the practice of self-praise. More recently, Ren and Guo (2020) further explored the pragmatic strategies of self-praise by analysing Weibo posts and recognised three main strategies, i.e., explicit self-praise without modification, modified explicit self-praise and implicit self-praise, with each comprising a variety of sub-strategies.

The studies reviewed above have thoroughly explored several Chinese speech acts in specific contexts, thus contributing significantly to our understanding of these speech acts, especially of the syntactic forms that may signal a given speech act, the pragmatic strategies that are available to perform a target speech act and the pragmatic effects of performing it in communication. Notwithstanding the strength and value, there are two issues that may need to be further addressed in Chinese speech act studies. On the one hand, most previous studies relied on data collected by DCTs, scripted discourse (e.g., TV shows) or a relatively small sample of data (e.g., recorded daily conversation), as indicated in the review above. Although such data source could be useful for some kinds of speech act studies such as cross-cultural ones, they, nevertheless, face some criticism. For instance, Ren and Woodfield (2016: 91) pointed out that "the DCT cannot examine conversational features typical in spoken discourse" and thus argued that "[f]urther research based on naturalistic data is needed to investigate how

refusals and other speech acts are realised in real communication". Other researchers such as Aijmer and Rühlemann (2015) and Weisser (2018) similarly highlighted the importance of using naturally occurring language as the data for investigating speech acts. In addition, the relatively small size of data sample also has an impact on the generalisability of the findings or observations (cf., Culpeper and Gillings, 2019). Taking the criticisms together points to the need to investigate speech acts by analysing a relatively large amount of authentic language use, speech acts in Chinese being no exception.

The other issue has already been briefly discussed above and is more noteworthy. Although previous studies have examined the pragmatic strategies or realisations for a given Chinese speech act, they have not attempted to systematically document and describe these strategies or realisations at a more generalised level, i.e., an attempt to capture the discourse-semantic regularities or patterns of these realisations. This is important because such systematic description of speech act realisations could offer an inventory of linguistic resources available to perform a given speech act, which could be particularly useful for L2 speech act teaching and learning. Presumably, the paucity of studies documenting and describing speech act realisations at the discourse-semantic level may be attributed to the lack of viable methods.

To remedy the problems discussed above, this study, drawing on data taken from a recently released corpus of spoken Chinese (Section 3.1), proposes a local grammar approach to describe speech act realisations in Chinese and argues that the proposed approach can be also extended to account for speech act realisations in other languages.

3. Towards a local grammar of exemplification in Chinese

3.1. Corpus and data retrieval

The corpus used in the present study is the newly released Diversified Spoken Chinese Uttered in Social Settings (hereafter DiSCUSS), which was created by the corpus research team led by Professor Jiajin Xu at Beijing Foreign Studies University, China, and can be accessed at http://114.251.154.212/cqp/. Types of discourse collected in the corpus include but were not limited to conversation, classroom discourse, interview, debate, and business discussion, amounting to 1,1268,838 words. DiSCUSS is designed as a balanced and representative corpus of modern spoken Chinese, and as such it is arguably a useful resource for researching speech acts in Chinese, given that speech acts typically occur in spoken language.[1]

In addition to the importance of exemplification in communication, another reason for selecting exemplification as the focus of the current investigation is that it was more frequently performed than other speech acts such as apology and thanking in DiSCUSS. As with exemplification in English, exemplification in Chinese is also typically signalled by a number of lexical markers. This linguistic conventionality indicates that exemplification is amenable to corpus search. Drawing on insights from previous studies (e.g., Paquot, 2008; Li, 2011; Su and Zhang, 2020) and based on manual examination of a small number of texts, we identified a set of conventional exemplificatory markers in Chinese and used them and their variants to search for and retrieve instances of exemplification in DiSCUSS. The quantitative information of these markers is given in Table 2.

Table 2
Exemplificatory markers and their frequency in DiSCUSS.

Item	Equivalent in English	Raw	Normed[a]
像	Like	1097	864.57
比如说	for example/for instance/let's say	471	371.21
就说	let's say	376	296.33
比如	e.g./such as	264	208.06
等等	etc.	171	134.77
例子	example	138	108.76
如	e.g./such as/include	51	40.19
之类	etc.	45	35.47
比方说	for example/for instance/let's say	38	29.95
以/拿 … 来说	let's say	18	14.19
例如	for example/for instance	13	10.25
好比	Like	11	8.67
以/拿 … 为例	take … as an example/instance	11	8.67
比方	for example/for instance	10	7.88
譬如	for example/for instance	8	6.3
举例	exemplify	7	5.52
譬如说	for example/for instance/let's say	6	4.73
Total		**2735**	**2155.52**

[a] The frequency was normalised per 1,000,000 words in this paper.

[1] As one reviewer suggested, exemplification may occur more frequently in written texts. We compared the frequency of exemplificatory markers between DiSCUSS (http://114.251.154.212/cqp/discuss/) and the UCLA Corpus of Written Chinese (http://114.251.154.212/cqp/ucla2/; both corpora can be accessed freely with both user name and password as 'test') to see if exemplification occur more frequently in spoken or written texts, which shows that, overall, exemplification in Chinese occurs more frequently in DiSCUSS than in the UCLA written corpus.

At this point, a few caveats should be mentioned. First, the markers listed in Table 2 are only the typical and conventional ones associated with exemplification in Chinese and, consequently, searching for them in our corpus would inevitably have left undetected those few instances which do not co-occur with anyone of them. Nevertheless, this would not undermine the value of the current investigation, as our primary aim is to explore the feasibility of applying local grammars to account for speech acts in languages other than English. Second, the frequency in Table 2 only indicates the times each marker occurs in DiSCUSS, but does not necessarily mean that all the instances containing these markers realise exemplification. For instance, it is observed that '像', as *like* in English, can not only be used to indicate exemplification, but may also be associated with figurative or analogical uses (e.g., *我感觉我像一个沙雕,* meaning '*I feel I'm like an idiot*' in English[2]). Such instances were excluded from the subsequent local grammar analysis, because they do not have the illocutionary force of exemplifying. Finally, unlike exemplification in English, Chinese exemplificatory markers may be combined to perform exemplification. For example, the instance *还有很多新晋的年轻的美国设计师, 比如像 Philip Lim …* (*There are many other emerging American designers such as Philip Lim …*) contains the two lexical marker '比如' (*such as*) and '像' (*like*). Such instances were only analysed and counted once.

Table 3
Terminologies for local grammar analyses of exemplification (adapted from Su and Zhang, 2020).

Terminology	Explanation	Example
Exemplified	The syntactic unit that indicates the term, concept or superordinate category that is being illustrated or specified.	***有些西方的学者***, 比如说丹托认为艺术已经终结。(***Some western scholars***, for example, Danto thought that art has come to an end.)
Exemplification	The syntactic unit that provides specific examples or subtypes for the illustration of the abstract term, concept or superordinate category.	在不同的场景下, 比如***火车站、公园、图书馆、马路、室内*** … (In different situations, such as ***train stations, parks, libraries, streets, indoors*** …)
Initiator	The syntactic unit that introduces or initiates the act of exemplifying.	***再***比如, 物理学家的宇宙是波函数。(***Again*** for example, the universe to physicists is a wave function.)
Indicator	The exemplificatory marker indicating the act of exemplifying is being performed.	资源包括很多方面, ***如***生产资料、核心技术、市场营销 … (Resources contain many aspects, ***such as*** means of production, core technology, marketing …)
Actor	The one who performs the act of exemplifying.	***我***举个小的例子。(***I*** will give you a simple example.)
Hinge	The syntactic unit that connects different parts of a local grammar pattern.	第一个例子***是***Facebook和Myspace。(The first example ***is*** Facebook and Myspace.)
Supporting statement	The syntactic unit that provides additional information for further illustration or specification.	有些西方的学者, 比如说丹托***认为艺术已经终结***。(Some western scholars, for example, Danto ***thought that art has come to an end***.)

3.2. Local grammar analyses of exemplification in Chinese

This section presents local grammar analyses of exemplification in Chinese. As discussed in Section 2.1, local grammar uses context-specific functional terms to analyse the corresponding syntactic units in instances of a given speech act, which in turn allows the researcher to identify local grammar patterns in a principled manner. One benefit of doing so is that each syntactic unit that has a pragmatic meaning can be translated into a term that is directly related to, and can explicitly reflect, its pragmatic meaning, thereby contributing to a transparent and fine-grained description of speech act instances. For our purpose, we adapted the terminologies used in Su and Zhang (2020), which were listed and succinctly explained in Table 3.

For the sake of clarity, we divided the analyses into three sets according to the similarity of local grammar patterns. The first set includes six patterns, in which the 'Exemplified' was presented at the clausal initial position of exemplificatory instances. The first two patterns in this set are probably the most basic ones associated with exemplification in Chinese, which has also been found to be the case in English (Su and Zhang, 2020). In these instances, the abstract concept or superordinate category being exemplified was presented in the left part of the clause and the subordinate or the specific subcategory in the right part, with the 'Indicator' presented in-between. The difference between the two patterns lies in the presence of the element providing additional information (which was labelled 'Supporting statement'), as shown in Tables 4 and 5.

Table 4
Exemplification realised as 'Exemplified + Indicator + Exemplification'.

Exemplified	Indicator	Exemplification
要不就是一堆其他教 Or a bunch of other religions	比如 such as	喇嘛教什么的 Lamaism etc.

The next two patterns are highly similar to those two discussed above. The only difference is that there is one more element which serves as a link between different pattern elements, as shown in Tables 6 and 7.

[2] All the Chinese examples used in the present study were translated into English by the authors.

Table 5
Exemplification realised as 'Exemplified + Indicator + Exemplification + Supporting statement'.

Exemplified	Indicator	Exemplification	Supporting statement
至少现在很多案例都能支持这一种观点 At least there are many cases that support this view	像 Like	微软的比尔盖茨, Facebook的扎克伯格等 Bill Gates in Microsoft, Zuckerberg in Facebook etc.	都是辍学后的超级成功者 both of whom are super successful people who dropped out of school

Table 6
Exemplification realised as 'Exemplified + Hinge + Indicator + Exemplification'.

Exemplified	Hinge	Indicator	Exemplification
… 更强大的检索功能 … more powerful searching functions	包括 including	像 like	一些高级检索以及引文检索 some advanced search and citation search

Table 7
Exemplification realised as 'Exemplified + Hinge + Indicator + Exemplification + Supporting statement'.

Exemplified	Hinge	Indicator	Exemplification	Supporting statement
还有一个就是交流 Another one is communication	就是 that is	比如说 for example	你跟我做这个访谈 the interview you had with me	其实就是一种交流的过程 is actually a process of communication

The peculiarity of the next pattern is that the 'Indicator', which in this pattern was typically realised by '等等' (*etc.*) and '之类' (*and so on*), was presented at the end of exemplificatory instances. An example of this pattern is given in Table 8.

Table 8
Exemplification realised as 'Exemplified + Hinge + Exemplification + Indicator'.

Exemplified	Hinge	Exemplification	Indicator
还包括了各种社会资源 It also includes all kinds of social resources	就是 which were	你的学历, 你的信誉和你的职位 your educational background, your credibility, your position	等等 etc.

The last pattern in this set involves the presence of an actor, i.e., the one who performs the act of exemplifying. In these cases, exemplification is typically realised by two clauses; that is, the preceding one presents the 'Exemplified' and the following the 'Exemplification', as illustrated in Table 9.

Table 9
Exemplification realised as 'Exemplified + Actor + Hinge + Indicator + Exemplification'.

Exemplified	Actor	Hinge	Indicator	Exemplification
我们这次文物清理是一个观念的变化 This time we had a conceptual change in cleaning up the artifacts	我 I'll	举个 present	例子 an example	过去清宫地毯是三大殿都铺着地毯 … In the past all the three great halls were carpeted in Qing Palace …

Patterns in the second set start with 'Initiator', i.e., the linguistic element initiating or introducing the act of exemplifying. Patterns in this set can be divided into pairs. The two patterns in the first pair can also be considered basic ones and were differentiated by the presence of 'Supporting statement', as shown in Tables 10 and 11.

Table 10
Exemplification realised as 'Initiator + Indicator + Exemplification'.

Initiator	Indicator	Exemplification
有可能未来 It is possible that in the future	像 like	在电影制作端, 也会参与电影的制作 the film production side would also participate in the production of movies

Table 11
Exemplification realised as 'Initiator + Indicator + Exemplification + Supporting statement'.

Initiator	Indicator	Exemplification	Supporting statement
… 因为 … because	像 like	周边, 桂林、柳州, 还有一些城市, 稍微大一点的 the surrounding areas, Guilin, Liuzhou, and some cities which are a bit larger	他们都会来到南宁这边活动 people from which will come to Nan'ning to hang out

The following two patterns have a different order of the local grammar elements associated with exemplification. That is, the 'Exemplification' is followed by, rather than precedes, the 'Indicator', as shown in Tables 12 and 13.

Table 12
Exemplification realised as 'Initiator + Exemplification + Indicator'.

Initiator	Exemplification	Indicator
后来又教过 Later (he) also taught	人类学、逻辑学、教育学、形而上学、哲学 anthropology, logic, education, metaphysics, philosophy	等等 and so on

Table 13
Exemplification realised as 'Initiator + Exemplification + Indicator + Supporting statement'.

Initiator	Exemplification	Indicator	Supporting statement
如果说 If	房子 housing	比如说 for example	可以解决了, 没有这种贷款的压力 … can be solved, without the pressure of mortgage …

Finally, this set also involves one pattern in which the actor is presented, i.e., the element that specifies the agent who performs the act of exemplifying (Table 14).

Table 14
Exemplification realised as 'Initiator + Actor + Hinge + Exemplification + Indicator'.

Initiator	Actor	Hinge	Exemplification	Indicator
很多例子 Many examples	我 I'll	就举一个 take the	电网 power grid	的例子 as an example

Patterns in the third set start with 'Indicator', i.e., the lexical marker indicating the act of exemplifying is being performed. These include patterns in which additional information of the 'Exemplification' was provided (Table 15) and those in which the 'Indicator' and 'Exemplification' was linked by a 'Hinge' (Table 16).

Table 15
Exemplification realised as 'Indicator + Exemplification + Supporting statement'.

Indicator	Exemplification	Supporting statement
像 Like	卢卡库也好, 莱万多夫斯基也好 Lukaku or Lewandowski	就是面对范戴克的一对一成功率太低 it's just that their one-on-one success rate against van Dijk is too low

Table 16
Exemplification realised as 'Indicator + Hinge + Exemplification'.

Indicator	Hinge	Exemplification
第二个例子 The second example	就是 would be	Twitter 的开放程度 the openness of Twitter

4. Results and discussion

In the previous section we briefly discussed the local grammar analyses of exemplification in Chinese, which allowed us to identify 13 local grammar patterns associated with exemplification in DiSCUSS. These patterns and their quantitative information were presented in Table 17.

We are now in a position to discuss some observations that can be tentatively drawn from the above local grammar analyses. First of all, the analyses show that it is indeed feasible to employ the local grammar approach to account for speech act realisations in Chinese. As with speech acts in English, the local grammar analyses also allow the researcher to generalise the discourse-semantic patternings out of diverse surface realisations associated with one specific speech act in Chinese; for example, our analyses categorised the 1452 instances of exemplification into 13 local grammar patterns. This suggests that local grammar analysis, as a kind of discourse-semantic analysis, can capture the regularities, or the phraseological tendency, of speech act realisations at a more generalised level (Su, 2017). This could not only contribute to a fine-grained and specialised description of speech act realisations, but also offer an inventory of the realisational patterns that can be used to perform a given speech act in a language. In other words, the resulting local grammar descriptions could have both significant implications for describing speech acts and their realisations and pedagogical applications for the teaching of L2 speech acts, which will be discussed in greater detail in Section 4.

Table 17
An overview of the local grammar patterns of exemplification in DiSCUSS.

Set	Pattern	Raw	Normed
Set 1	Exemplified + Indicator + Exemplification	585	461.05
	Exemplified + Indicator + Exemplification + Supporting statement	171	134.77
	Exemplified + Hinge + Exemplification + Indicator	95	74.87
	Exemplified + Hinge + Indicator + Exemplification	29	22.86
	Exemplified + Actor + Hinge + Indicator + Exemplification	23	18.13
	Exemplified + Hinge + Indicator + Exemplification + Supporting statement	21	16.55
	Subtotal	**926**	**729.80**
Set 2	Initiator + Indicator + Exemplification	245	193.09
	Initiator + Indicator + Exemplification + Supporting statement	163	128.46
	Initiator + Exemplification + Indicator + Supporting statement	42	33.10
	Initiator + Exemplification + Indicator	21	16.55
	Initiator + Actor + Hinge + Exemplification + Indicator	3	2.36
	Subtotal	**474**	**373.57**
Set 3	Indicator + Exemplification + Supporting statement	47	37.04
	Indicator + Hinge + Exemplification	5	3.94
	Subtotal	**52**	**40.98**
Total		**1452**	**1144.35**

Secondly, our intuition may suggest that in all cases of exemplification there would be the 'Exemplified', the 'Exemplification', and the 'Indicator'. On the one hand, our analyses did show that in all cases there are the 'Exemplification' and the 'Indicator' and in the majority of cases the 'Exemplified' is also present, which confirms that the three can be considered core semantic elements associated with exemplification. On the other hand, it is also observed that patterns in Set 2 and 3 did not contain the element 'Exemplified', which appears to be surprising. We thus further examined instances realising these patterns and found that this may be attributed to the spoken nature of our data. Specifically, we found that patterns in Set 2 and 3 mainly occurred in conversations, where instances realising exemplification are discontinuous, i.e., exemplification is realised by two or more conversational turns. Such instances of exemplification were mainly used to introduce a new 'thing' (Example 1) or switch to a new topic (Example 2).

(1)
张 肯定只是一个人主要做。
Zhang: It's definitely just one person being responsible for the work.
周 对。
Zhou: Yeah, sure.
孙： 你们俩，谁写稿子写得比较好得？
Sun: You two, who is better at writing?
周： 写稿子。写什么稿？
Zhou: Writing. What kind of writing?
孙： *就写，比如演讲稿。*
Sun: *Write, like a speech.*
(2)
王凯： … 重要的是你那个店的效益好不好。我在的那个店，是效益最好的一个，因为它是带批发的，其他的店都是零售。
Kai Wang: … The point was whether your store was profitable or not. The store which I worked in was the most profitable one, because it provides wholesaling, while the other stores are just retailers.
鲁豫： *像这样的人生不同的经历，对于做演员是一件好事吧。*
Yu Lu: *A different life experience like this must be a good thing for being an actor, isn't it?*
王凯： 是好事 …
Kai Wang: Yes, it is …

In the two examples, utterances realising exemplification were in italics. In Example (1), there is no abstract concept or term that is being exemplified in the utterance of exemplification (i.e., *Write, like a speech*), but the utterance does realise the speech act of exemplifying and its function here is to introduce a specific (sub)type of writing. In Example (2), the host Yu Lu performed the speech act of exemplifying by commenting on the kind of life experiences Kai Wang had, which allowed the host to switch the topic. In these examples, the 'Exemplified' is often blurred, though which can be inferred from the conversation. We suggest that it is this kind of face-to-face conversation that allowed the omission of the 'Exemplified' in such utterances of exemplification. This may also account for the lower frequency of those patterns involving the 'Actor'. That is, in face-to-face conversation, there is less need for one to clearly express that s/he is going to illustrate or exemplify an abstract concept or a superordinate category, because such concept or category usually has already been presented in the preceding utterances (which is the case at least in our data). A further implication, then, is that local grammar analyses could reveal some nuances of speech act realisations.

Thirdly, previous studies adopting a local grammar approach to speech acts in English have shown that local grammar terminologies (e.g., Exemplified, Exemplification) may be realised in a variety of ways and by syntactic units of various length, ranging from individual words to phrases and to clauses. Our analyses suggest that this is also true for the local grammar terminologies used to account for exemplification in Chinese. However, compared with an earlier investigation into exemplification in English (Su and Zhang, 2020), we observed that the terminologies used in the current investigation are more

likely to be realised by clausal units. While it remains unclear whether this is always the case for speech acts in Chinese, the observation indicates that the resulting local grammar descriptions may facilitate cross-linguistic investigation into speech act realisations (see more discussion in Section 4). At the same time, such cross-linguistic differences will need to be carefully considered when analysing speech act instances in a given language from the perspective of local grammar.

As discussed in previous studies, one advantage of local grammars is that it allows the researcher to quantify the realisational patterns associated with a given speech act. This not only provides quantitative information on the typicality of each pattern (i.e., the higher the frequency, the more typical the realisational pattern is), as shown in Table 17, but more notably offers a way that can facilitate contrastive speech act analysis. Specifically, it has been observed that rather than considering instances co-occurring with the same lexical marker as the same realisation, local grammar analyses suggest that such instances may realise distinct patterns (Su, 2020, 2021). We found that this also applies to the local grammar analyses of speech acts in Chinese. Take '比如' (roughly an equivalent to '*for example/for instance/such as*' in English) as an example. The analyses of instances co-occurring with '比如' lead to the identification of several distinct patterns, as shown in Table 18.

Table 18
Local grammar analyses of instances co-occurring with '比如'.

Exemplified	Indicator	Exemplification
很多患者会有神经发育方面的疾病 Some patients will have neurodevelopmental diseases	比如 such as	ADHD就是多动症 ADHD, which is attention deficit and hyperactivity disorder.

Exemplified	Indicator	Exemplification	Supporting statement
我们经常发生的买卖行为, 有些人会签订合同 Generally, when we purchase or sell commodities, some of us would sign a contract.	比如 For instance,	你家去买房子买车 when your family go to buy a house, or a car,	是不是都要签一个协议呀 you need to sign a contract, don't you?

Initiator	Indicator	Exemplification
有一些老师 There are some teachers,	比如 for example,	他们会每个人开一次例会 each of them would have a regular meeting.

Likewise, instances co-occurring with different markers may realise the same local grammar pattern. For instance, the pattern 'Exemplified + Indicator + Exemplification' can be realised by instances co-occurring with several exemplificatory markers in Chinese, as illustrated in Table 19.

Table 19
Exemplified + Indicator + Exemplification realised by instances co-occurring with different exemplificatory markers.

Exemplified	Indicator	Exemplification
二位导演之前带过非常经典的作品给大家 You two as directors have filmed very classic works for audiences before	像 like	《无间道》《伤城》《窃听风云》 *Infernal Affairs*, *Confession of Pain*, *Overheard*
或者说一些非常小的湖泊 Or some very small lakes	比方说 for instance,	只有一个足球场那么大 it is as large as a football court
童年期的一些创伤 Some traumas in childhood	比如说 for example	战争、地震等 wars, earthquakes, and so on
… 第一批历史文化名城名单共24处 … The first batch of historical and cultural cities has listed 24 places in total	如 including	北京、杭州、开封 … Beijing, Hangzhou, Kaifeng …

The above discussion reinforces the observation made in previous studies that local grammar descriptions offer a way to more reliably quantify the realisational patterns of a given speech act, providing an alternative approach to contrastive speech act studies. For instance, Hunston (2002) noted that local grammars can quantify the means in which a meaning or a discourse function can be performed; and Su (2020, 2021) recently demonstrated how local grammars can be applied into such contrastive studies by employing the local grammar approach to trace the diachronic changes of apologies in American and British English, respectively. The point, then, is that local grammar could be a useful approach to describe speech act realisations and the resulting local grammar descriptions can further facilitate contrastive investigation into speech acts across contexts, cultures, and languages, as will be further discussed in Section 4.

5. Further discussion

As discussed above, our study shows that it is indeed feasible to employ the local grammar approach to account for the speech act of exemplifying in Chinese. To further explore whether the local grammar approach could also be used to describe other speech acts in various languages, in Table 20 we present the local grammar analyses of expressions that have nearly the same meaning and can be considered equivalents for making apologies[3] in five languages, i.e., Chinese, English, French, German, and Japanese.

Table 20
Local grammar analyses of apologies in Chinese, English, French, German, and Japanese.

(1)

LGT / Language	Apologising	Specification
Chinese	对不起	我迟到了
English	Sorry	I'm late
French	pardon	Je suis en retard
German	Entschuldigung	dass ich mich verspätet habe
Japanese	**Specification**	**Apologising**
	遅れて	すみません

(2)

LGT / Language	Apologiser	Hinge	Intensifier	Apologising	Specification
Chinese	我		很	抱歉	没能帮到你
English	I	am	so	sorry	for not being able to help you
French	Je	suis	si	désolé	que je ne pouvais pas vous aider
German	Es tut mir			leid	dass ich dir nicht habe helfen können
Japanese	**Specification**		**Intensifier**	**Apologising**	
	お役に立てず		大変	申し訳ございません	

(3)

LGT / Language	Apologiser	Specification	Apologising
Chinese	我	为我犯的错	道歉
	Apologiser	**Apologising**	**Specification**
English	I	apologise	for the mistake I made
French	Je	m'excuse	de l'erreur que j'ai commise
German	Ich	entschuldige mich	für meinen Fehler
Japanese	**Specification**		**Apologising**
	私の不注意からご迷惑をおかけしましたこと		申し訳ございません

[3] It is perhaps worth mentioning that here we used apology as an example because it can better illustrate our point, whereas we did not simply focus on apology in the present study mainly because there are only a handful of instances of apologies in DiSCUSS. This may be due to that, as a high-context culture, Chinese people normally do not use too many expressive speech acts such as apologies, thanking, and compliments (see for example Wong's (2010) discussion about 'thanking' in familial context in Asian cultures). Sometimes, the recipient may even regard apologies as insincere or odd in the Chinese context, especially when the interlocutors had a close relationship.

(4)

LG / T / Language	Intensifier	Forgiveness-seeking	Specification
Chinese	请	原谅	我的无知
English	Please	forgive	my ignorance
French	S'il vous plaît	pardonnez	mon ignorance
German	Bitte	entschuldige	meinen Irrtum
Japanese	**Specification**	**Intensifier**	**Forgiveness-seeking**
	無知な私	を許し	てください

While Table 20 has only presented a simplistic rendering of local grammar analyses of speech acts in the five languages, it at least provides some corroborative evidence to support our argument that local grammar can be a useful and viable approach to account for speech act realisations in general. Additionally, the analyses also show that language-specific features such as word order would have an impact on the local grammar analyses of speech act realisations. For instance, the reason or offence for an apology (which was labelled 'Specification') in Japanese was usually presented at the initial position of speech act instances, realising patterns that were different from those identified in the other four languages.

The proposal that local grammars can be applied to account for speech acts in various languages offers ample opportunities to further speech act studies and L2 speech act teaching. First, it presents a way to systematically describe speech act realisations associated with a given speech act in a given language, as has been demonstrated in previous studies on speech acts in English and the current investigation into exemplification in Chinese as well as the brief discussion of apologies in five different languages. It is expected that the resulting local grammar descriptions could provide fresh insights into the classification of speech acts, based on the assumption that instances which can be analysed as the same local grammar pattern can be regarded as realising the same speech act. In other words, local grammar analysis might help to identify types of speech acts and further explore the validity of a taxonomy of speech acts, which is important, as currently there was no fine-grained taxonomy of speech acts that was widely accepted to the pragmatics community.

Second, local grammar analyses allow the researcher to quantify the ways in which a given speech act can be performed, not by counting the frequency of formal markers but by capturing the underlying discourse-semantic regularity of speech act instances, as discussed in Section 3.3. This means that local grammar can be an alternative approach to contrastive speech act studies such as cross-linguistic and cross-cultural investigation into speech acts, which is arguably the most notable value of the proposed local grammar approach to account for speech acts in various languages. For instance, even in the few examples presented in Table 20, cross-linguistic differences of apologies can be observed between the five languages; e.g., apology in Japanese appears to stand out in that the 'Actor' of an apology was usually not presented and the 'Specification' occurred at the beginning of apology instances, whereas apologies in the other four languages share much more in common. For cross-cultural speech act studies, the resulting local grammar description also allows the researcher to quantify and subsequently compare the discourse-semantic patternings of a given speech act across sociocultural contexts, based on which cross-cultural differences can be revealed (Su and Lu in press). Such cross-cultural speech act studies are valuable because "while speech acts themselves are universal, the socio-pragmatic rules or norms governing the appropriate enactment of any given speech act vary greatly among cultures and languages" (DeCapua and Dunham, 2007: 319).

Turning to pedagogical applications. As indicated in Ren's (2022) review of L2 pragmatics instruction, consensus has been generally reached that pragmatic competence is teachable (see also Kasper, 1997) and pragmatic instruction is useful, which is also true for the teaching of L2 Chinese speech acts. What needs to be done is to shift the attention from exploring whether pragmatic instruction is helpful to exploring how to effectively teach L2 pragmatic competence (Ren, 2022), in which L2 speech act competence is an essential component. The question, then, is how to teach L2 speech acts. This relates to the third value of research on local grammars of speech acts that we would like to discuss in more detail, that is, local grammars of speech acts developed of a given language could facilitate L2 speech act teaching.

Previous studies have generally observed that L2 learners cannot perform speech acts in contextually appropriate ways. In the case of exemplification in English, for example, Hinkel (2004) and Siepmann (2005) reported that English L2 learners often have difficulty performing appropriately exemplification. The reason for this inadequacy has been partly attributed to L2 learners' limited repertoire of language resources (Paquot,2008). For the same reason, Chinese L2 learners might also face the same challenges when performing speech acts in Chinese. This points to the need to systematically document and describe speech act realisations. Local grammars of speech acts, as shown in previous studies and the current investigation, well document the linguistic forms and their associated local grammar patterns, offering teachers and learners an inventory of linguistic resources that are available to perform a given speech act. In addition, local grammars of speech acts developed in a

given corpus allow one to quantify the frequency of each pattern, as discussed above. The frequency generally corresponds to the typicality of a realisational pattern, which can also be used to inform learners of the typical ways to perform a given speech act in the target language.

This pedagogical implication of local grammar research has also been briefly discussed in early studies, though focusing on local grammars of speech acts in English (e.g., Su, 2017; Su and Zhang, 2020). It is arguable that, as with local grammars developed of speech acts in English, local grammars developed of speech acts in other languages could also be usefully applied in L2 speech act teaching. For instance, the local grammar of exemplification in Chinese developed in the present study can be used to teach or inform Chinese as a foreign or second language learners how to perform exemplification in Chinese. While a lot remains to be done to explore how findings of local grammars of speech acts can be effectively applied in L2 speech act teaching, it has been found that, in the case of exemplification in English, English as a foreign language learners welcomed this approach in pedagogical practice (Zhang and Su, 2021). Arguably, learners of Chinese or other languages as a foreign/second language will most likely welcome the local grammar approach to L2 speech act teaching and learning as well.

Notwithstanding the strengths and opportunities, applying the local grammar approach to research speech acts in various languages in practice faces a number of challenges. Here we discuss three general ones. As the enterprise of developing local grammars of speech acts requires a corpus that is representative of the target language, the first challenge relates to the lack of such representative corpora in most languages. For English, there are several representative corpora such as the British National Corpus and the Corpus of Contemporary American English; however, such corpora still await to be compiled for many other languages. Provided corpora were available of a target language, the second challenge relates to the identification and retrieval of instances realising the target speech act. This is challenging because, while realisations of most speech acts have been shown to be highly routinised or signalled by formal makers or constructions (Aijmer, 1996; Pérez-Hernández, 2021), there are also few speech acts that may not only be explicitly expressed or signalled by linguistic resources, but also implicitly by non-linguistic ones. This poses challenges for (semi-)automatically identifying and retrieving instances of such speech acts in corpora. Finally, an additional challenge relates to the identification of local grammar terminologies that can be used to analyse speech acts in a given language. To overcome this challenge, Su (2020) suggested two guiding principles. One is termed the principle of transparency, which means that terminologies should be proposed within the specific context of the target speech act and explicitly reflect the communicative function of the syntactic unit being analysed. The other is termed the principle of economy, referring to a tendency of using a limited number of terminologies for the local grammar analysis of the target speech act. Arguably, observing the two principles would potentially help researchers to identify a set of context-specific terminologies that are appropriate for the subsequent local grammar analysis.

6. Conclusion

This exploratory study has reported on an attempt to extend the local grammar approach to account for speech acts in Chinese, aiming to investigate the feasibility and applicability of local grammars in accounting for speech acts in languages other than English. Our analyses of exemplification in Chinese and the brief analyses of apology in five selected languages provide evidence that local grammars can indeed be applied to account for speech acts in various languages. Furthermore, our discussion suggests that the proposed local grammar approach not only offers a way to document and describe the linguistic realisations of a target speech act in a given language, but more notably a way that can facilitate cross-linguistic and cross-cultural speech act studies, which in turn indicates the value of employing the local grammar approach to speech act studies in general.

Based on our previous studies and the current investigation, we further highlight several contributions that local grammars can uniquely make to speech act studies. Firstly, in addition to supporting Hunston and Sinclair's (2000: 101) argument that local grammar analysis "would be more simple, more precise, and more useful than an analysis using a general grammar",[5] the study further demonstrates that the resulting local grammar descriptions of speech act realisations are more transparent and finer-grained in that each syntactic unit has been analysed by using a term that is directly related to its pragmatic or communicative function. Secondly, the resulting local grammar description provides an inventory of linguistic forms and their associated discourse-semantic patterns that are available to perform a specific speech act, which could be particularly useful for L2 speech act teaching. Thirdly, compared with the other more qualitative approaches to speech act studies (e.g., Conversation Analysis), the local grammar approach allows one to calculate the frequency of each pattern, which not only indicates the typicality of each pattern in realising a given speech act (i.e., the more frequent, the more typical), but also offers a viable method to quantify the realisational patterns of a given speech act across languages and/or contexts. This has important implications for contrastive speech act studies in general, especially for cross-linguistic and cross-cultural investigation into speech acts, as has been comprehensively discussed in Section 4.

Overall, the current investigation has amassed sufficient evidence to show the feasibility and value of employing the local grammar approach to account for speech acts in various languages. The subsequent discussion further suggests that local

[4] "It would be simple in that each local grammar would use a limited number of terms, although the number of local grammars might need to be fairly extensive. It would be precise in that each local grammar could be stated in its own terms, without the need to fit in with more general statement. It would be useful because the terminology used would be reasonably transparent and would immediately relate the grammar and lexis of each part of the text to its discourse function" (Hunston and Sinclair, 2000: 101).

grammars of speech acts could provide ample opportunities to advance speech act studies, especially contrastive ones (e.g., cross-linguistic and cross-cultural investigation) and L2 speech act teaching and learning. We would thus look forward to more research that develops local grammars of speech acts in various languages, including but not limited to Chinese and English, as well as research that employs the local grammar approach to explore the cross-linguistic and/or cross-cultural differences in performing speech acts. We argue that such research can significantly take forward speech act studies.

Ethic statement

The study reported in this paper has not been published previously or submitted for consideration in any other journals.

Author contributions

Hang Su: Conceptualisation; Data collection; Data analysis; Funding acquisition; Project administration; Writing – review & editing. **Yixin Fu**: Data collection; Data analysis; Writing – review & editing.

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Declaration of competing interest

None.

Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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